a spontaneous riot or communal outbreak. No riot of this kind is purely accidental.

Mobs do not materialise suddenly or spontaneously. It is not as if on any given day, crowds and processions will abruptly gather and take out a march. Nor is it possible that those pelting stones at them will instinctively accumulate an arsenal of projectiles or hurl these from rooftops. Mobilising people on either side of the communal divide requires planning, organisation, resources and implementation.

Given the plethora of CCTV footage and video clips, it should not be too difficult, especially when the faces of several partisans are clearly visible, to identify them and bring them in for questioning to find out who their managers or handlers are. But such a line of investigation is rarely, if ever, deployed. Because the agents in the drama of the macabre are always shielded rather than exposed. Their very success and replicability depend on their obscurity.

How else can we explain why the first convictions in the anti-Sikh pogroms of 1984 did not occur till 34 years later? Despite over 10 high-level commissions and committees of inquiry. The overriding aim, it is obvious, was to mask rather than reveal the truth.

THE AGENTS IN THE DRAMA OF THE MACABRE ARE ALWAYS SHIELDED RATHER THAN EXPOSED

In the aftermath of the Ramnavami and Hanuman Jayanti riots, is the Hindu-Muslim divide deepening? To find answers to such questions, reliable information, let alone deep knowledge, is hard to come by. Instead, we are inundated by armed falsehood and weaponised misinformation. Tremendous effort is needed to sift the true from the false, the real from the make-believe. Because untruths or half-truths are circulated so vigorously and vociferously, the task of reality-seekers has become even more difficult.

We may never know exactly what happened or why. But we are not totally without clues, evidence, or methods to figure it out. Is appeasement being replaced by aggression? If so, mainstream political parties, even those in power, are apparently colluding with extremist anti-India forces in a deadly dance of mimetic and retaliatory violence. While the former may think they will profit from such polarisation, the concomitant fuelling of the subversive activities of the latter does not augur well for our Republic. Let us not forget how India was made to look bad by a communal conflagration in northeast Delhi when US president Donald Trump came calling for 48 hours on February 24-25, 2020.

Whether in JNU or the rest of India, conflicts over territory or power will exploit existing faultlines. In the subcontinent, these just happen to be vehemently religious. This is why the Partition of India took place and the ethnic cleansing of Hindus in Pakistan continues apace.

Can our youth make a difference? Yes, they can. By sending out a loud and clear message against riots, whether religious or ideological. But they need knowledge as well as understanding. Both, however, are in short supply these days. ■

Illustration by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY